

JET MILES, KOHLI MANIA AND BORDER TALES: A CRICKET SOJOURN IN AUSTRALIA

Perth's Singapore-aligned time zone aids players and cricket writers, while Canberra's tree-lined avenues and laidback charm **offer a tranquil** contrast to bustling capitals.

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A trip Down Under commences with multiple flights on the Chennai-Bengaluru-Kuala Lumpur-Perth sector. A November 18th night and 19th day are almost entirely lost to the accumulation of jet miles. It is time for the Border-Gavaskar Trophy Test series pitting old rivals India and Australia, and in Perth, local papers even embrace the Indian vernacular

Rain plays spoilsport: An electronic screen announces the abandonment of day one of the two-day tour match between Prime Minister's XI and India at Manuka Oval in Canberra.AFP

while doing supplements on Virat Kohli.

After Sachin Tendulkar, Kohli has embedded himself in Aussie hearts. Aggressive batter, not averse to revealing his emotions and anger, perhaps fans Down Under see a kindred spirit in him. And with a second innings unbeaten 100, he does come to the party at the Optus Stadium. A gigantic structure that gives the vibe of a massive black forest cake from the outside and becomes a huge venue open to multiple sports from the inside.

Does it have the character of the nearby WACA Ground? No. But is it practical and convenient? Yes. And

with that, most arguments about architecture and aesthetics cease. A stadium is never about the structure; it is also about its sporting lore, and perhaps after a few decades, Optus will acquire a nostalgic sheen, which it lacks now.

India does its bit to enhance the ground's brand recall as a come-from-behind 295-run triumph is secured on November 25.

After being bundled out for 150, the visitor finds battering rams in skipper Jasprit Bumrah's pace, K.L. Rahul's solidity, Yashasvi

